



BEFORE

By spring 1862, Confederate survival was threatened by a series of military setbacks. Jackson's campaign in the Shenandoah Valley looked set to be another.

POOR RELATIONS

General Stonewall Jackson was placed in command of the **Confederate Department of Northern Virginia** in October 1861, with responsibility for the defense of the 150-mile (240-km) long Shenandoah Valley. The following winter his insistence on campaigning in harsh weather **brought his troops close to mutiny**. Some of his officers complained to politicians and it was with some difficulty that he was **dissuaded from resigning**.

UNION VICTORIES

The Confederacy's **setbacks in the Western Theater** in the first months of 1862 included the **losses of New Orleans and of forts Henry and Donelson**. In Virginia, by May, Union General George B. McClellan's **Army of the Potomac** had landed on **the Virginia Peninsula** and had advanced to within a **few miles of Richmond** (see **The Peninsula Campaign**).

Union forces made the first move in the campaign in March 1862. Their aim was to eliminate any offensive threat from General Jackson's small army in the Valley, thereby allowing Union troops to be switched from the defense of Washington to the attack on Richmond. Major General Nathaniel Banks led an army across the Potomac River, forcing Jackson, who was heavily outnumbered, to withdraw south from his base at Winchester.

Pursuing the Confederates for some 50 miles (80km), a Union division under Brigadier General James Shields lost contact and assumed Jackson had withdrawn. But as Shields returned toward Winchester, Jackson pursued him and counterattacked. Wounded, Shields ceded command to Colonel Nathan Kimball, who defeated the Confederates at Kernstown on March 23. Jackson retreated, having lost around a third of his force, yet the strategic effect of the battle was everything the Confederates could have desired. Startled by Jackson's aggression, Union commanders redoubled their efforts to crush him. As long as Jackson kept campaigning, Union troops would not be transferred from Washington to Richmond.

Jackson's success in the subsequent campaign would depend on two factors: speed of movement, achieved by driving his marching men so hard they became known as the "foot cavalry;" and superior